C23W12 · THURSDAY, APRIL 16, 2026

Y COMBINATOR & FUNDRAISING FOUNDATIONS

Company structure, SAFEs, accelerators, and how to write a YC application.

USER COUNT LEADERBOARD

Live from your API endpoints.

Vouch	49	+5
Rekindled	33	+5
FreeWeight	30	NEW
Evidence of Life	29	+2
Sift	17	+0
Tripable	14	+2
Circles	14	+0
HAUNT	10	endpoint pending
Misfit AI	9	+1
QuestCity	–	no endpoint
Roam	–	no endpoint
Recruitr	–	no endpoint

TEAM PRESENTATIONS

~10 min each (5 min present, 5 min feedback).

DATE	CLASS	TEAM 1	TEAM 2	TEAM 3
Thu, Apr 9	c21	Circles ✓	Evidence of Life ✓	QuestCity ✓
Tue, Apr 14	c22	FreeWeight ✓	Rekindled ✓	
Thu, Apr 16 (today)	c23	HAUNT	Misfit AI	Roam
Tue, Apr 21	c24	Tripable	Vouch	
Thu, Apr 23	c25	Millionaires	Recruitr	Sift

Format

Show the product live. Walk through your data. Where are you stuck?

You Choose the Focus

Practice presenting a demo. Get feedback from peers on your product. You choose how to structure your 5 minutes based on these goals.

HAUNT

MISFIT AI

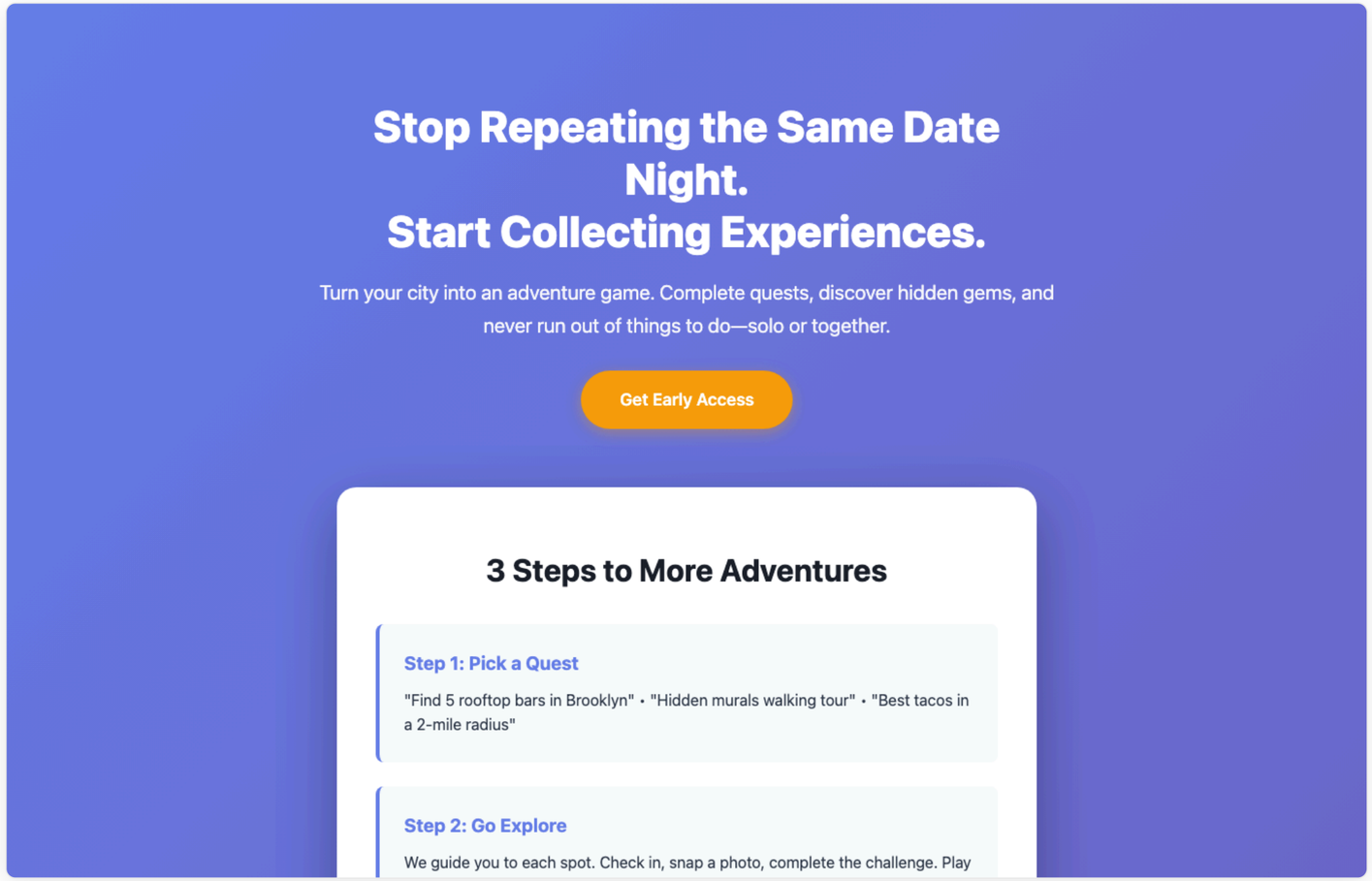
ROAM

WHAT WE'RE SEEING IN YOUR WORK

YOUR PRIORITIES SHOULD UPDATE WITH EVERY NEW DATA POINT AND CUSTOMER INTERACTION.

The teams that are doing well aren't the ones with the most features.
They're the ones reading their data and using it to decide what to build next.

QUESTCITY


Stop Repeating the Same Date Night.
Start Collecting Experiences.
Turn your city into an adventure game. Complete quests, discover hidden gems, and never run out of things to do—solo or together.
Get Early Access
3 Steps to More Adventures
Step 1: Pick a Quest
"Find 5 rooftop bars in Brooklyn" • "Hidden murals walking tour" • "Best tacos in a 2-mile radius"
Step 2: Go Explore
We guide you to each spot. Check in, snap a photo, complete the challenge. Play

WHAT THEIR USERS SAID

Maya, UX designer:
"I had no idea what I was getting into for the first 3 minutes."

James & Priya, a couple:
"Do we share one account or have separate accounts?"

Derek, competitive gamer:
"What stops me from faking the photo?"

Rachel, skeptical PM:
Called out the fake testimonials immediately, unprompted.

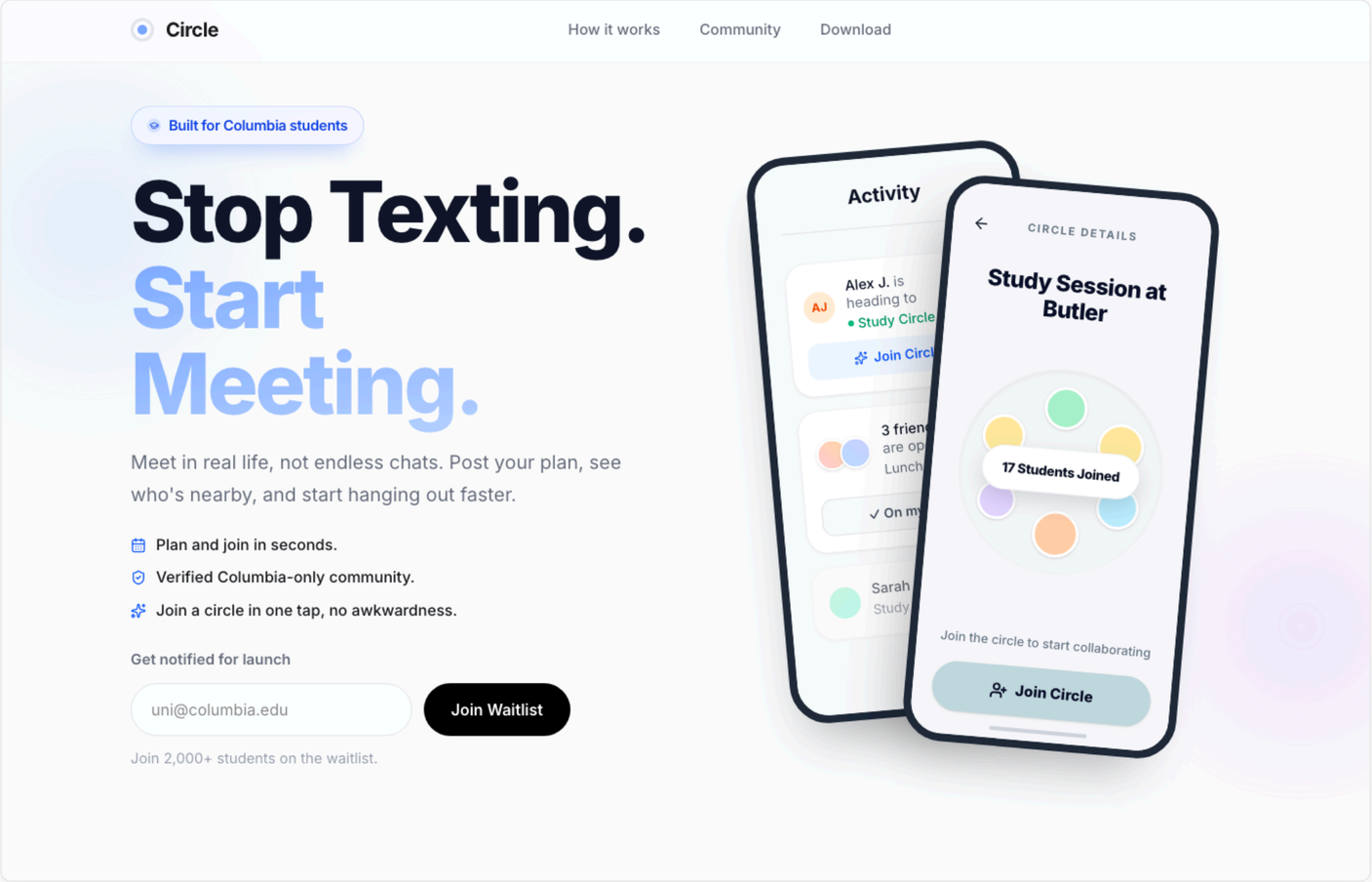
WHAT THEY CHANGED

- 3-screen onboarding before the first quest
- Location surfacing via Google Maps API
- Couple mode mechanics defined
- Replaced fake testimonials with real waitlist count
- Added privacy note to check-in

"A PRODUCT PEOPLE IMMEDIATELY WANT — AND AN ONBOARDING EXPERIENCE THAT IMMEDIATELY LOSES THEM."

— QuestCity team, after 4 user tests

CIRCLES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Stop Texting.
Start
Meeting.
Meet in real life, not endless chats. Post your plan, see who's nearby, and start hanging out faster.
Plan and join in seconds.
Verified Columbia-only community.
Join a circle in one tap, no awkwardness.
Get notified for launch
uni@columbia.edu
Join Waitlist
Join 2,000+ students on the waitlist.
Activity
AJ
Alex J. is heading to
Study Circle
CIRCLE DETAILS
Study Session at Butler
17 Students Joined
Join the circle to start collaborating
Join Circle

WHAT TESTING FOUND

- Location input has no map confirmation
- "Hang out" copy made a user think it was a **dating app**
- Chat was buried at the bottom of the page
- HEIC photos broke uploads
- No way to invite friends in-app

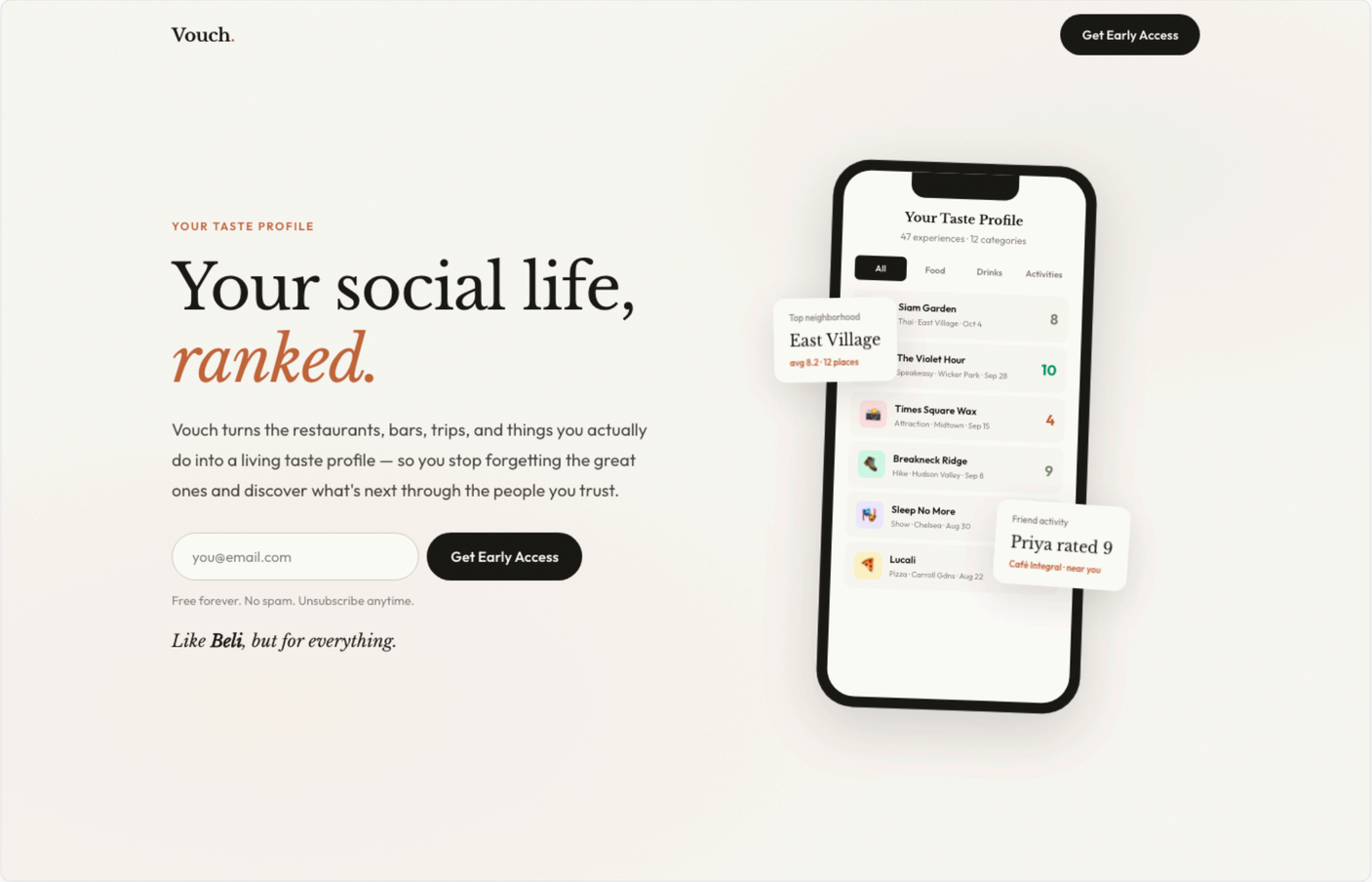
THIS WEEK'S BUILD LIST

1. Google Maps for locations
2. Copy overhaul: "hang out" → "student connection"
3. Raise chat in the UI
4. HEIC support + in-app sharing

"REMOVING ONBOARDING FRICTION RESTORES TRUST — AND GETS USERS TO INVITE THEIR FRIENDS."

— Circles weekly update, April 14

VOUCH


Vouch.
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YOUR TASTE PROFILE
Your social life, ranked.
Vouch turns the restaurants, bars, trips, and things you actually do into a living taste profile — so you stop forgetting the great ones and discover what's next through the people you trust.
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Get Early Access
Free forever. No spam. Unsubscribe anytime.
Like Beli, but for everything.
Your Taste Profile
47 experiences · 12 categories
All
Food
Drinks
Activities
Top neighborhood
East Village
avg 8.2 · 12 places
Siam Garden
Thai · East Village · Oct 4
8
The Violet Hour
Speakeasy · Wicker Park · Sep 28
10
Times Square Wax
Attraction · Midtown · Sep 15
4
Breakneck Ridge
Hike · Hudson Valley · Sep 8
9
Sleep No More
Show · Chelsea · Aug 30
Lucali
Pizza · Carroll Gdns · Aug 22
Friend activity
Priya rated 9
Café Integral · near you

THE SOCIAL GRAPH IS THE PRODUCT.

They were treating it like a feature. It should be the foundation.

WHAT THEY DID ABOUT IT

- Changed copy: "your friends are rating too" → "**the people you trust are your best algorithm**"
- Shareable profile card for iMessage & WhatsApp
- Designed aha moment: rate 3 → share → friend rates → you get notified

"30 REAL USERS WHO FOLLOW EACH OTHER BEATS 300 STRANGERS."

— Vouch roadmap

ROAM

"NO STRONG PULL, NO ONE ASKING FOR ACCESS."

— Roam roadmap, opening line

WHAT THEY'RE BUILDING

- Clean and instrument data properly
- Tighten one core loop: Save → Organize → Revisit → Add
- Test 2-3 user segments manually
- One distribution experiment (TikTok)

WHAT THEY'RE NOT BUILDING

- No social features
- No AI recommendations
- No full launch
- No paid growth
- No infrastructure beyond basics

"IF IT DOESN'T IMPROVE RETENTION OR USER CLARITY, WE DON'T BUILD IT."

— Roam's rule for the next 7 days

STILL LEARNING THE VALUE PROP

TEAMS ARE STILL GETTING NEW SIGNAL

Rekindled: peer reviewers weren't sure if it was a dating app or a friend app.

Circles: a user tester read "hang out" as dating-app language.

Both teams are now iterating on copy and framing.

THIS IS A MESSY PROCESS. IT DOESN'T FOLLOW A CLEAN ORDER.

You're working on UX and analytics now, and you're still getting value-prop feedback. That's normal. Capture it all.

PATTERNS ACROSS TEAMS

The teams with the best data are making the best decisions

QuestCity ran 4 user tests and knows exactly what to fix. Circles tested and rebuilt their priority list. Vouch identified their core insight from peer review.

Several teams still have blank results tables

If your growth strategy doc has no results, you're not running experiments — you're writing plans.

The "and why" matters more than the "what"

The teams that answer "why" from their data are iterating.

HOW STARTUPS WORK

FROM PROJECT TO COMPANY

YOU INCORPORATE

- Usually a **Delaware C-corp**
- Established corporate law, VC-friendly precedent
- Creates a legal entity separate from you
- You issue stock to founders (usually 10M shares)

WHY C-CORP? NOT LLC?

- Can issue **preferred stock** (what investors get)
- Can have unlimited shareholders
- What every VC expects to see
- LLCs are fine for lifestyle businesses
- C-corps are for venture-scale

THE CAP TABLE IS WHO OWNS WHAT.

At founding: 100% belongs to founders. Every time you raise, you sell a piece.

THE FUNDRAISING LADDER

Each stage requires more evidence. You trade equity for capital at every step.

STAGE	TYPICAL AMOUNT	WHAT YOU NEED	WHO INVESTS
Accelerator	$150K-$500K	Idea + team + early signal	YC, Techstars, 500 Global
Pre-seed	$250K-$1.5M	MVP + early user signal	Angels, pre-seed VCs
Seed	$1M-$5M	Traction + revenue or strong engagement	Seed funds, angels, some VCs
Series A	$5M-$20M	Product-market fit + growth metrics	VCs
Series B+	$20M+	Scaling a proven business	Larger VCs, growth funds

💡 **Where you are now:** Accelerator / pre-seed stage. You have teams, MVPs, and early signal. That's exactly what the first rung requires.

SAFE: SIMPLE AGREEMENT FOR FUTURE EQUITY

Invented by YC. Used at pre-seed and seed.

> *"I give you $X now. You give me equity later, at a discount, when you do a priced round."*

5 pages instead of 30+. No lawyers. No board seat. No maturity date.

SAFE TERMS TO KNOW

- **Valuation cap:** max valuation at which the SAFE converts
- **Discount rate:** 15-20% off the next round's price
- **MFN** ("Most Favored Nation"): investor can opt into better terms if you later give someone else a better deal

DILUTION OVER TIME

Two founders, 50/50 at founding.

Watch what happens over four rounds.

DILUTION THROUGH FOUR ROUNDS

ROUND	EACH FOUNDER	OPTION POOL	INVESTORS	COMPANY VALUE	EACH FOUNDER'S STAKE
Founding	50%	—	—	$0	$0
+ Accelerator ($500K for 7%)	46.5%	—	7%	$7M	**$3.3M**
+ Seed ($2M + 10% pool)	32.5%	10%	25%	$15M	**$4.9M**
+ Series A ($10M)	26%	8%	40%	$60M	**$15.6M**
+ Series B ($30M)	22%	7%	49%	$250M	**$55M**

50% → 22%. AND $0 → $55M EACH.

You own less of the company. The company is worth much more. That's almost always the right trade.

INCUBATORS VS. ACCELERATORS

	INCUBATOR	ACCELERATOR
Duration	1-3 years	3-6 months
Structure	Rolling, no cohort	Cohort-based, competitive
Investment	Usually none	$150K-$500K for 5-10%
Stage	Pre-idea, exploring	MVP + early signal
Ends with	Ongoing support	Demo Day pitch to investors

COLUMBIA HAS BOTH

Columbia Startup Lab (incubator)

SoHo workspace. $325/month for alumni. No equity taken.

Almaworks (accelerator)

Feeds the Columbia Venture Competition ($250K in prizes).

THE MAJOR ACCELERATORS

Current deal terms. The money matters less than the network and credibility.

PROGRAM	INVESTMENT	EQUITY	DURATION
Y Combinator	$500K	7% fixed + MFN SAFE	~3 months
Techstars	$220K	5% + MFN SAFE	13 weeks
500 Global	$150K	6%	4 months
Betaworks (NYC)	$200K	Varies	3 months
ERA (NYC)	Varies	Varies	4 months

💡 **~80% of accelerator graduates** secure follow-on funding after Demo Day. The credibility signal and investor network are often worth more than the capital.

YC: THE DEAL

$500K total.

- $125K for a fixed 7% stake (post-money SAFE)
- $375K on an uncapped MFN SAFE
- No fees, no milestone requirements
- Pro-rata rights in future rounds

ACCEPTANCE RATE: 0.6-1%

S25 was 0.6%. Harder than most top law schools.

40% OF FUNDED COMPANIES ARE IDEA-STAGE.

Straight from YC's own FAQ. You don't need to be "ready."

WHO GETS FUNDED

- B2B is ~84% of funded companies
- AI is increasingly dominant
- Technical co-founder ≈ 5x better odds
- 10-minute Zoom interviews

MISCONCEPTION #1

❌ "I need an accelerator to raise money."

Many companies raise pre-seed and seed directly from angels and VCs.

Accelerators are a tool, not a prerequisite.

MISCONCEPTION #2

❌ "The money is the main benefit."

$500K gets you 6 months of runway.

The network changes your trajectory for years.

MISCONCEPTION #3

❌ "7% equity is too expensive."

7% of a company worth nothing is nothing.

If YC helps you grow, that 7% was the best deal you ever made.

MISCONCEPTION #4

❌ "Demo Day is when you raise."

Demo Day creates momentum.

Actual fundraising happens in the weeks after.

THE YC APPLICATION

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. YC FUNDS FOUNDERS, NOT IDEAS.

Reddit was accepted after YC rejected their original idea. They built Reddit **the same day**.

Airbnb had no growth. Paul Graham funded them because the founders were "impossible not to like."

40% of funded companies are at idea stage only.

2. VAGUENESS IS THE #1 KILLER.

Michael Seibel estimates **half of all applications** leave readers with no idea what the company does.

The fix: replace adjectives with nouns. Claims with numbers. Marketing language with plain English.

3. THE APPLICATION IS A DIAGNOSTIC.

It forces you to answer questions you may have never discussed with your co-founder.

How is equity split? Who are the competitors? What do you understand that they don't?

If you can't answer these, **the problem isn't the application. It's the startup.**

THE FIVE CRITICAL QUESTIONS

Q1: 50-CHARACTER DESCRIPTION

> *"Describe what your company does in 50 characters or less."*

✓ "Accounting software for freelance designers."

× "AI-powered platform disrupting B2B workflows."

Q2: WHAT ARE YOU MAKING?

> *"What is your company going to make?"*

Paul Graham's test: describe it specifically enough that someone could reproduce the concept.

✓ "A database with a wiki-like interface."

× "We're redefining collaboration."

Q3: FOUNDER ACHIEVEMENTS

> *"Something impressive each founder has built or achieved."*

YC calls this **the most important question on the application.**

✓ "Built an e-commerce store to $40K MRR."

× "Exceptionally dedicated with a proven track record."

Q4: WHY THIS IDEA?

> *"Why did you pick this idea? Do you have domain expertise?"*

Best answer: **personal experience.**

- ✓ "I spent 8 years in the industry and watched every team struggle with X."
- ✓ "We interviewed 40 CFOs; 32 described the same pain point."

Q5: COMPETITORS

> *"Who are your competitors? What do you understand that they don't?"*

Never say "we have no competitors."

That signals you don't understand your market. Name real competitors, then articulate your specific insight gap in one sentence.

UNDERRATED QUESTION #1

> *"Tell us about the time you most successfully hacked some (non-computer) system."*

YC seeks people who "**like to beat the system**," not "obedient, middle-of-the-road people."

This question can elevate a weak application.

A REAL ANSWER

One founder wanted a premium domain name that wasn't for sale.

1. Researched the owner on LinkedIn
2. Flew to NYC
3. Hand-delivered a letter
4. Sent cupcakes

He got the domain. He also got into YC.

UNDERRATED QUESTION #2

> *"Tell us about an alternative company or idea you might work on."*

Paul Graham checks this when the main idea doesn't land but the founders seem strong.

Some companies get funded for the backup idea, not the primary application.

THE 1-MINUTE VIDEO

THE RULES

- **1 minute.** All founders must appear.
- **No scripts.** Talk from bullet points.
- **No demo, no music, no graphics.**
- **Bad audio kills you.** Bad video is forgivable.
- **Equal airtime** between founders.

WHAT THEY'RE ACTUALLY EVALUATING

- Can you explain it clearly and naturally?
- Do you have real chemistry with your co-founders?
- Is the energy authentic?

TEAM BEATS IDEA. EVERY TIME.

YC will accept founders with a bad idea and ask them to change it.

REDDIT

Applied with a mobile food-ordering idea.

YC rejected the idea. But they liked the founders.

They built Reddit that same day.

AIRBNB

Had no growth when they applied.

> *"We didn't even like the idea that much. Funded because the founders seemed so full of energy that it was impossible not to like them."*

— Paul Graham

BREX

Applied with a VR business.

Pivoted to corporate credit cards mid-batch after realizing they knew nothing about VR but everything about payments.

ONU / LOULA

The interview opened with:

> *"We love your backgrounds, but we hate your idea."*

They spent the interview brainstorming a new direction. Then got accepted.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Spend as much application space conveying founder quality as explaining the idea.

Your user testing. Your iteration speed. Your honesty about what's broken.

That's founder quality on paper.

~50% OF EVERY ACCEPTED YC BATCH APPLIED BEFORE.

Rejection is part of the process, not the end of it.

RELATE: 6 APPLICATIONS

5 rejections. Then accepted.

What changed:

- Pivoted to B2B
- Got paying customers
- Eliminated vague language

INSFORGE: 6 ATTEMPTS

Breakthrough moment:

- 20 deep user interviews
- Launch Week hit 1.5M impressions
- #1 on Product Hunt

A YC partner reached out to *them*.

CLOSE: 7 APPLICATIONS

Apps 1-6: education platform. No prototype. No team. No users.

App 7: working product, real user feedback.

Accepted.

SAME INFO BETWEEN APPLICATIONS = NO EXECUTION.
NEW PROOF = MOMENTUM.

Even a rejection positions you for the next cycle.

THE TARPIT WARNING

CLASSIC TARPIT IDEAS

- Music discovery apps
- Restaurant discovery apps
- Social apps for meeting people
- Event discovery platforms

DON'T PRETEND YOU'RE FIRST.

Acknowledge the tarpit directly. Then show why you're different.

HOW TO ESCAPE THE TARPIT

- Name what's different **in one sentence**
- Show **retention data**, not just signups
- "We know 50 teams have tried this. Here's why we're different: [evidence]."

YC S26 DEADLINE: MAY 4, 2026

8pm PT. 18 days from today.

S26 LOGISTICS

- **Deadline:** May 4, 2026, 8pm PT
- **Decisions by:** June 5
- **Program:** July-September, San Francisco
- **Review:** Rolling — early submissions get more interview slots

APPLY.

1-2 hours of work. Upside: $500K and the best startup network in the world.

TUESDAY: YC APPLICATION WORKSHOP

DRAFT ANSWERS TO FOUR QUESTIONS

1. What does your company do?
2. Why did you pick this idea?
3. What have you built, and what traction do you have?
4. The 1-minute video

DELIVERABLES

- **NEW:** Draft YC application by Tuesday
- **Due today:** Analytics Snapshot
- **Tuesdays:** Weekly updates
- **April 23:** Feature freeze
- **May 4:** YC S26 deadline

THE 7-DAY COUNTDOWN

DAYS 1-2: APR 16-17

- Fix your most broken thing (probably onboarding)
- Get your endpoint live if it isn't
- Fill in your blank results tables

DAYS 3-5: APR 18-20

- Execute your cold start strategy with intensity
- Get 10 active users in one dense group
- Draft your YC application

DAYS 6-7: APR 21-23

- YC workshop Tuesday (c24)
- Final fixes only
- April 23: feature freeze. Ship what you have.

THE ONLY TEST THAT MATTERS:

Give your product to a stranger. Watch what they do.

Do they come back the next day?

FEATURE FREEZE: APRIL 23.

7 days. After that: measurement and pitch prep only.

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